SPORTS

# How Pumping Iron Turned Gators Into Wrecking Balls

Florida's new coaching staff wanted to return their team to college football's elite. The first step was to lift tons and tons of weight.



By Robert O'Connell

Florida's $44 million football coach had barely set foot inside his team's practice facility when he noticed a glaring issue.

As he surveyed the men he was being paid to lead, Jon Sumrall, a former linebacker who long ago hung up his shoulderpads, realized that these supposed behemoths couldn't lift all that much weight. In fact, many couldn't even lift as much as Sumrall, who is now 44 years old.

"Jon could outlift virtually all of our defensive backs, and a lot of our wide receivers," said Florida strength coach Rusty Whitt, who doubles as Sumrall's workout partner.

So before he designed a single play, Sumrall spent the offseason hellbent on a much more fundamental mission. In order to guide the Gators back to the top of college football, he first needed to make the Gators stronger—by more than 7 tons.

"We're training so they can be a stronger, more physical, more violent football player," Sumrall explained.

Florida's roster didn't just get stronger. With a focus on four cornerstone exercises, it improved its previous "max" lifts by a combined *14,443 pounds*—enough muscle to pick up an African elephant. And three weeks into the season, the beefed-up Gators have become one of college football's largest surprises. Florida has rolled to three straight wins by a combined 99 points, and enters Saturday's showdown with No. 4 Ole Miss as the betting favorite.

It all began with Whitt, a former special forces sergeant in the Army who served as Sumrall's trusted muscle-builder at previous stops at Troy and Tulane, remodeling Florida's weight room.

**14,443**

Combined weight, in pounds, that Florida's roster improved its previous "max" lifts

He first ripped out a patch of artificial grass—a creature comfort running down the middle of the facility—and replaced it with rubber flooring. The reason was simple. He wanted it to be easier to clean up when players dug so deep that they emptied their stomachs.

"It's really hard to clean that out of AstroTurf," Whitt said.

The gut-busting workouts imposed by Sumrall and Whitt centered on four lifts: power clean, bench, squat and dead lift. The coaches rearranged racks to face each other directly, turning weightlifting sessions into heated internal competitions. Offensive linemen squared up against defensive linemen, while running backs took on safeties.

Over a summer of these mano a mano showdowns, the Gators' strength numbers steadily climbed. Star running back Jadan Baugh squatted such an astronomical number—600 pounds—that the conditioning staff prohibited him from throwing any more weight on the machine.



Florida's Jadan Baugh stars on the field, top, and the weight room, above.

Whitt called the approach Eating the Elephant.

"How do you eat an elephant?" Whitt likes to say. "One bite at a time."

The bulking philosophy is out of step with the modern game, where most young coaches spend their time drawing up space-age offenses and recruiting lightning-fast players to execute them. But Sumrall and Whitt believe in an old-school tenet of the gridiron. Hitting your opponent as hard as possible never goes out of style.

The numbers back them up. Last season, Florida's opponents outgained the Gators on the ground by 206 yards. Just months into their new strength regimen, though, the Gators are now rushing for 246 yards per game—an average of 151.3 more than their opponents.

Whitt pointed to a 53-yard touchdown against Auburn as the perfect example of all that new muscle turning into points on the board. Baugh, a Heisman candidate with tree-trunk thighs, carried the ball into the end zone following a block from tight end Lacota Dippre that knocked a defender straight to the ground and opened up the lane.

The only problem, in the coaches' view, was that Dippre stood flexing his new muscles over his fallen opponent—which could have drawn a penalty for unsportsmanlike conduct.

"We have to be careful how much flexing we do these days," Whitt said.

There's also one other benefit to Florida's new strength program that never shows up in the stat sheet or on the scoreboard. Every week, Sumrall and Whitt spend hours lifting together, a stress release from the long hours of scouting opponents and running drills.

Monday is for bench pressing and Tuesday is squats, but they reserve biceps and shoulders for the end of the week.

"We're trying to get the arms to look good for TV on Saturday," Sumrall said.

PETER JONELIET/AP; UAA COMMUNICATIONS

# The NFL's New Prohibition: Beer Celebrations

By Andrew Beaton

**AFTER SAN FRANCISCO 49ERS** fullback Kyle Juszczyk hauled in a touchdown pass against the Miami Dolphins last weekend, he trotted out his signature celebration. The player nicknamed "Juice" used his hand to pantomime guzzling down a drink.

In the NFL's eyes, that drink was a beer. And it would soon become extraordinarily expensive.

The NFL fined Juszczyk $14,926 for violating Rule 12, Section 3, Article 1 of its rulebook because it was deemed an unsportsmanlike act—and he wasn't alone. This past week, two other players—Indianapolis Colts offensive lineman Matt Goncalves and Dallas Cowboys tight end Jake Ferguson—were also punished for their beery celebrations.

"Your imitation of chugging a beer constituted an offensive demonstration and could reasonably be construed as being in poor taste," the league wrote to the players.

Juszczyk says he doesn't even drink beer. Still, the move landed him in the NFL's latest celebration crackdown.

The league had made a special point in recent years of keeping celebrations demure. In 2024, the league issued a flurry of fines to players who pantomimed firing a gun with their fingers. And now, it's coming after the pantomime chuggers.



The NFL fined San Francisco 49ers fullback Kyle Juszczyk $14,926 after his touchdown celebration.

Goncalves was fined for his celebration during Indianapolis's overtime loss to the Kansas City Chiefs last Sunday night. After Colts tight end Tyler Warren caught a touchdown pass in the first quarter, he appeared to use the football to mimic taking the top off a bottle. Then he handed it to Goncalves, who mimed drinking from the ball before spiking it.

"It was a soda," fellow Colts tight end Mo Alie-Cox wrote on X, adding an emoji with an eyebrow raised and another one crying laughing.

Ferguson met the same fate. In his case, after a touchdown against the Washington Commanders, he seemed to use the ball to imitate shotgunning a beer. (That choreography involved punching a hole in the side of a beer can before opening it and chugging it.)

It was all part of the NFL's broader mission to punish celebrations that it believes cross a line, and this past week alone was a kegger for that. Detroit Lions wide receiver Amon-Ra St. Brown said he received multiple fines for imitating smoking. Cincinnati Bengals receivers Ja'Marr Chase and Tee Higgins were both fined for making a gesture the league deemed to be obscene.

These fines are always subject to appeals by the players, and no player may have a stronger case than Juszczyk. After all, it's a celebration he has done throughout his career without any problem. And his nickname is so well-known that the whole stadium yells it whenever he makes a big play.

"When I celebrate, I celebrate by drinking juice," he said. "So I was as surprised as anybody when I got a fine."

KELLEY L COX/AP

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